Here's a basic outline:

- *Rename your web service.* Naming is important. In this scenario, your Rails app is really the API or back end, so you should name it as such.
- *Create a custom image for running your JavaScript front-end app.* In the same way we've created a custom image to run our Rails app, you would do the same but for your JS front end. Its Dockerfile could build on top of a standard Node.js image,[1] adding the app-specific setup required.
- *Create a separate, front-end service in your docker-compose.yml.* This would be your standalone JavaScript application. You would configure, via environment variables, the API endpoint it should use (the domain name and port of the Rails API).

If, on the other hand, you're using Rails to serve up your front end, that means using the facilities that Rails provides. Rails offers two mechanisms for serving up JavaScript front ends: the (Sprockets-based) asset pipeline or the new Webpacker approach added in Rails 5.1.

The traditional Sprockets-based asset pipeline works out of the box without any special setup. As part of running the Rails server, your assets will automatically be compiled and served up in your views in the standard Rails way. We'll see an example of this in the upcoming testing chapter on page 95.

Getting your Rails app working with Webpacker takes a little bit more setup with Docker. Since this is such a popular approach, we're going to guide you through how to set this up throughout the rest of the chapter.

Rails JavaScript Front End with Webpacker

Rails has included a way to build rich JavaScript front ends into your apps since version 5.1, using a gem called webpacker. Webpacker has a modular architecture, allowing you to integrate different front-end technologies, be it React, Ember, Vue.js, or even Elm.

Using React as an example, let's see how we'd configure Webpacker in our Dockerized app.

First things first. Webpacker requires Yarn and a current version of Node. This requires an update to our Docker image:

```
Line 1  FROM ruby:2.6
-       LABEL maintainer="rob@DockerForRailsDevelopers.com"
-
```

1. https://hub.docker.com/_/node/